

A Rabbit's Life

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Chapter 1: Birth

Darkness first. Then warmth.

Body pressed against body against body. Many heartbeats, many rhythms of breathing. The small space full of us, the pile shifting as bodies squirm inward, toward the warmth. Milk-scent surrounding everything. Fur against fur, warm and soft, each breath heavy with the others' scent.

Wood beneath the body. Not earth, though earth pulls from below. A hollow that should exist, a darkness that should run deeper than this. The body holds a shape the world refuses to give. Instead wood planks, straw scattered thin, the bitter smell of shavings. Each breath brings the dry smell of wood, mixed with the sweetness of straw.

The pile breathes together. Hearts beating their separate rhythms, quick and small. Shared warmth between all of us. Air thick with breath.

Then light.

First light is too bright. Eyes squeeze closed. A sliver cuts through the darkness, widening as something opens above. Sound comes with the light. Movement beyond the walls, vibration traveling through wood. Not-mother. Darkness again. Cold enters before the opening closes, a draft of fresh air through the warmth.

Later, light again. The sliver widens to a square. Scent rushes in. Hay. Earth. Something warm and living but far too large.

The pattern repeats. Light-dark. Light-dark.

Mother-scent arrives.

The pile shifts toward it, noses seeking. Large body settling briefly at the edge of the nest box, warmth available. Fur soft and warm, carrying the scent of milk and grass. Bodies press close, mouths finding source. Bellies fill. Then mother-warmth withdraws. Scent fades beyond the walls.

Bodies press together again, making warmth between ourselves. The space where mother was, empty until the next milk-scent comes. Cold where her warmth had been.

Light-dark. Light-dark. Milk-scent, then absence. The pattern repeats.

The world begins to open.

Eyes that were sealed now see. Shapes emerge from darkness. This body, that body, another body beside. The pile separates into bodies, each carrying its own scent beneath the shared milk-smell.

One scent becomes familiar. Sweet milk-breath. Always against the right flank. Warmth where mother is absent. The softest fur of all.

Ears that were flat now lift. Sound arrives differently. Vibrations through wood become distinct noises. Gate sounds. Footsteps. Voices beyond walls. Each sound carries vibration through the planks into the body.

The pile still huddles, but bodies begin to differentiate. This one moves often. That one stays still. Another body, the familiar one, always near.

Mother's scent grows fainter with each passing of the light.

Where mother-fur once pressed on all sides, now empty space opens. The pile fills the gap, bodies nestled tighter. Cold seeps into the edges where warmth once was.

Hunger pulls in a way warmth never did. Sharp. Insistent. Noses seeking, finding only wood, straw, the scent of each other.

Milk-source visits less often, then not at all.

One day noses search for mother-scent and find nothing. Only wood, straw, the scents of those who remain. The source is gone.

Bodies press tighter that night. The pile smaller now, the familiar scent-body always close, warmth shared between all of us still.

The square opens wider than before.

Tall-bodies, more than one, different scents mixing. Voices carrying vibration down through air into the nest box. Hands visible at the opening. Scents sweep in, strange and sharp.

The pile shifts, bodies pressing toward corners. Hearts racing.

Hands descend into the space. Large, dry, carrying strange scents. Smooth and cold against fur. Reaching toward the pile.

One body is lifted into the air. Not this body. Another. The scent trails upward, away, beyond the wooden walls. The pile shifts, emptier now.

The scent does not return.

Hands again. Another body rising. Another scent moving away, fading beyond reach of the nest box. Gone.

The pile smaller. More space between bodies where press and warmth had been. Cold finding gaps.

Hands reach toward this body. The world tilts, lifts. Air all around, no ground, no warmth. Held in wrong-warmth, dry and smooth, no fur. Heart strikes fast. Muscles tight. The pull toward below, toward burrow, but there is no below. Only hands, only air.

Then lowered again. Placed back into straw.

One scent remains close. The familiar one. Sweet milk-breath. The one who always pressed against the right flank.

Two bodies now where many had been. The nest box too large, straw visible in corners that the pile once filled. Two heartbeats instead of many. Two breathing rhythms.

The one who remains presses close. Same milk-scent. Same mother-touch. Same darkness from the beginning. Her scent the most familiar scent, more familiar than wood, than straw, than this body's own fur. Her warmth the only warmth that remains.

Body against body. Heartbeat answering heartbeat.

same

sister

Nest-sister. The scent carries what words cannot: shared birth, shared mother. The one who remained when others were taken.

Days pass in the rhythm of light and dark.

The body grows stronger. The space shrinks with each passing day. Walls closing in.

Legs that once only pushed now find use. The body lifts, wobbles, tips sideways. Tries again. Rising, falling, rising. The small space allows only a few hops before wood walls stop everything. Paws strike hard against wood, vibration rising through the legs.

The pull remains, downward, toward enclosed safety that exists nowhere in this wooden world. Paws scratch at wood planks, seeking the darkness below. Nothing yields.

Sister scratches too. Both pawing at the same corner, the same unyielding surface. The pull persists without an answer.

The square opens again. Tall-bodies at the opening. Two of them, different sizes, carrying scents that don't belong. Sweet scents. Sharp scents. None of them milk, none of them mother.

Hands descend. Warmth, but wrong-warmth, dry and smooth, no fur. The body lifts into the air, held in cupped palms. Heart racing. Muscles tight. The urge to burrow. But there is no below. Only hands, only air.

Sister hangs in another pair of hands nearby. Held. Both held.

Then lowered again. Hands retreating.

The two bodies find each other immediately, nose to fur, warmth seeking warmth. Heart still racing, but slowing. Same. Still same.

The absence fills the space.

Two bodies curled together in the corner where the pile once filled all edges. The wooden walls hold them in. The absent earth pulls them down. The darkness of the nest box is not the safe darkness the body craves.

But sister is here. Same scent. Same warmth. Same heartbeat, close enough to feel.

The square opens one morning and doesn't close.

Light pours in, brighter than before. Scent rushes through the opening. Wood, straw, but different. Fresh. New space beyond.

Space.

More space. The pull that has lived in the body since the first darkness strains toward it. Out there, through the opening: a larger world. Still wooden, still walled, but larger.

And something else in the scent. Dry grass. Something that smells almost like what the body needs.

Sister presses close behind. Both of them straining toward the opening, toward the new space, toward what has always been missing.

A hop forward. Another. The edge of the square. The beginning of the wider world.

Chapter 2: First World

The square stands open.

Light pours through, carrying scents from outside, sharp and unfamiliar. The body freezes, nose working. Not the close darkness of the nest box, not milk-scent and mother-warmth. Something else entirely.

Sister behind, nose pushed forward, whiskers trembling.

One hop forward. The floor changes. Broader boards, walls farther apart, ceiling higher. Light falls in slats through gaps. This is the hutch proper.

A metal dish sits in one corner, filled with small hard pellets that smell of dried grass and grain. Another holds water.

The body approaches. Hunger drives deeper than caution. Teeth close. Crunch.

Dry. Dense. Breaking between teeth in a way that demands grinding, not sucking. The taste spreads: grass, grain, something substantial. The belly responds.

Sister waits behind. She doesn't approach until the first body steps back. Then she moves forward, teeth working on what remains.

One approaches first, one waits. The order establishes itself.

Hay hangs from a wooden rack. The body stretches upward, teeth catching strands, pulling them free. Slow grinding. The belly fills differently, not with liquid warmth but with a dry weight that settles deeper.

Sister joins, pulling hay from the opposite side. Both eating now.

Milk is gone. This remains.

Footsteps beyond the wooden walls. Metal on metal, clicking open. The gate.

The body freezes. Heart quickening.

The gate swings inward and light floods the space. Tall-bodies fill the opening, two of them, both carrying strange layered scents. Fabric and skin and something sweet.

Hands reach in.

The body flattens against the far corner. Sister does the same, both small against the wood, hearts racing, muscles pulled tight with nowhere to flee.

But the hands reach for the food dish, lifting it away. The water dish, pouring out what's old, filling it new. The hay rack, pushing fresh strands through.

Then the hands retreat. The gate closes.

The hearts slow. The bodies unfreeze.

The pattern begins: gate sound, then hands, then food, then retreat. The body learns the sound. The sound brings fullness, not danger.

Light changes angle through the gaps, higher, then lower, then gone. The body follows the shifts. Bright: movement. Dim: rest. Dark: sister pressed close.

The nose presses to a gap between boards, seeking scents from beyond: earth, grass, living things in open air.

The nose to the same gap, over and over. Earth. The pull toward earth persists, but the gap offers only scent, never earth itself.

Sister mounts sometimes. Weight pressing down. The body stays beneath it, waiting until the weight lifts.

The bodies grow. Legs longer. Ears higher. Hops that once covered half the space now cross it entirely.

The gate sound becomes the only event that breaks the rhythm. Beyond the walls, scents continue to arrive. Earth. Grass. Rain. Things the body can smell but cannot reach.

The pulling grows stronger.

Earth scent rises thick today, damp and rich. Rain has fallen somewhere beyond. Paws scratch at the boards near the gap. The wood holds firm. The body scratches harder, the pull persisting against the wood. Dig. Burrow.

The gate sounds.

Both bodies freeze. The gate opens. Light pours in, brighter than before. And with it: earth scent, overwhelming, close, not filtered through gaps but flowing directly through the opening.

The gate doesn't close.

A shape stands in the opening, the smaller tall-body. Hands move. The opening remains.

The body approaches slowly. Nose forward. Ears high.

Ground changes beneath the paws. Not wood. Not straw. Something that gives slightly, that releases scent with each press of weight. Earth. Real earth.

Behind, sister waits at the threshold.

Another step. The earth holds. The air moves, not trapped between walls but flowing, coming from everywhere. Grass, hawthorn bark, distant rain, creatures beyond sight.

The body lowers, pressing belly to ground. The earth is cool against skin, alive in ways that wood never was. The pull that has lived inside since the first darkness, the pull toward down, toward enclosed, toward earth, that pull finds something to answer it at last.

Sister steps through the gate.

Two bodies on earth now. Ears high and swiveling, noses mapping the impossible new world. The walls still stand, farther apart, but walls still. The sky opens above.

But earth beneath.

Earth beneath.



Figure 1: First World

Chapter 3: First Earth

Earth changes everything.

The body moves differently here, where ground gives beneath weight, where each hop leaves a mark that scent can return to. The yard stretches wider than the hutch, bounded by wire, and in one corner, the hawthorn.

The hawthorn rises from the ground at an angle, bark rough and gray. At its base, where roots push up through packed earth, a hollow has formed. Not deep. Not enclosed. But the closest thing to burrow this ground has offered.

The body approaches, nose lowered. Scent here in layers: bark and earth and old leaves decomposing, gathering into something rich. The hollow is shallow, barely longer than the body, but its shape stirs something older than memory.

The body circles. Lowers. Presses into the curved space.

Rain comes. The body crouches in the hawthorn hollow while water runs down branches, drips from leaves. Fur grows damp. Cold seeps in.

Sister settles alongside, seeking warmth. Two bodies fitted into the hollow, fur wet against fur, heartbeats close.

The rain stops. Scent rises thick from soaked earth. Paws sink into softened ground. The soil yields, finally, to the pressure of digging. The body scratches at the earth near the hawthorn roots, and the earth moves. Not much. Not far. But it moves.

The depression deepens to a paw's length. Then stops. Something beneath resists.

Not a burrow. Not the darkness down that the body craves. Just a hollow in the ground, deep enough to crouch in, not deep enough to disappear into.

Between wire and ground, where rain has softened earth and the wire has not been set deep, a space has opened. Wide enough for a body pressed flat.

Sister circles the gap. Nose working.

Then pushes nose through, shoulders following, but stops. The wire catches. Too tight still. She pulls back, returns to the hollow.

The gap remains.

The gap widens over days. The body gnaws at the wire in quiet hours. The strands fray, part.

One morning: the gap wide enough. The body approaches, tests it. Through the first gap, then through a second gap in the outer fence. Beyond: trees, leaf litter, forest.

The body moves forward. Scent rises in layers so thick the nose can barely read them. No familiar trace. Ground soft with fallen leaves. The body moves forward, one hop, then another.

Afternoon. Predator scent, sudden and sharp. Fox. The heart quickens, muscles tightening.

Heart racing. Ears flat. The body runs. Just away.

Twilight finds the body beneath a dense bush, trembling. The darkness holds no boundaries. Sounds multiply. Rustling. Calls above. Footsteps nearby.

The body does not sleep.

Dawn arrives. The body emerges, stiff. The nose searches for the scent of the hutch, of the hawthorn, of sister waiting.

The body follows the trail.

The fence appears through trees. Beyond it, the hawthorn, and in the hollow, a shape that moves. Sister.

The heart surges. The body pushes through the gaps.

Sister presses close immediately, nose working over every inch of fur, reading the night. Tongue follows, grooming the places where twigs caught.

Settling into the hollow beside sister, bodies fitted together. The trembling slows. The heart slows.

The tall-bodies find the gnawed wire.

Their voices carry alarm. They crouch at the bottom of the wire, fingers probing the severed strands. The hands return with tools. With new wire. Metal against metal, the sound of twisting. The work takes most of an afternoon. The gnawed gap disappears beneath fresh mesh, tighter than before, buried deeper in soil.

The body circles the perimeter when the tall-bodies have gone. Nose pressed to wire, to the places where gaps used to form.

No gap.

The wire holds firm. The boundary is complete again.

No hole. Wall. More wall.

Sister returns to the hollow and settles to groom. Nothing in her movements marks a change. The walls were always walls.

The body settles into the hollow. Sister alongside. The warmth gathers between them.

The gate sounds. The hands bring food. The rhythm resumes.

The hawthorn hollow grows deeper by inches, worn by use rather than dug by paws. The pull toward earth persists through every season, finding the same barrier each time.

The body moves between outdoor hollow and indoor hutch, earth and wood. Both are known. Both are safe. Neither is the burrow the body still craves.

Close enough. Not enough. Close enough.

Chapter 4: Seasons

Summer heat fades into autumn cool. The hawthorn drops its leaves, bare branches scratching at gray sky. Fur thickens of itself, the body preparing for cold coming, darkness lengthening, earth hardening. Underfur beneath the outer coat, a warm layer growing against the skin.

First frost arrives. Grass crackles underfoot, rimmed white. Water in the dish wears a skin of ice. The nose pushes through to drink, cold shocking the tongue. Sister stays in the wooden hutch longer now, pressed into straw. Both bodies thickening against winter, warming each other where fur meets fur.

Days shrink to pale stretches between long nights. Earth freezes solid, hard beneath the paws. No digging now, no pressing into the hollow beneath the hawthorn. The hollow holds only frost.

The hutch becomes everything. Both bodies press together, sharing heat the way they shared it in the first darkness. Straw piles around them, trapping warmth. Breath visible in the cold air, small clouds rising and vanishing.

The tall-bodies bring more food. Extra hay, extra pellets. The bodies eat more, filling against the cold, storing what the season demands.

The turn comes slowly. Ice on the water thins, then disappears. Days stretch. Air softens until the body can leave the hutch without shivering. Warmth returns by degrees, warming the fur, loosening the muscles.

The earth loosens. Ground that was hard gives beneath the paws.

New shoots push through dark soil. The body eats them, fresh taste filling the belly with something missing all winter. The juice of green between the teeth, sweeter than dry hay. The hawthorn hollow deepens with use. Paths across the yard packed hard, worn bare by endless crossing.

The body circles the perimeter each morning, nose pressed to wire. The gap that once opened no longer forms. The reinforced barrier holds firm. The body circles anyway, pattern persisting even after possibility has ended.

The beyond still sends its scents through the wire. The body carries the forest in muscle-memory: soft leaf litter, thick scents, trembling and cold. The body stays on this side of the wire. Still circling, testing, finding nothing.

Sister stays still. She rests in the hollow during summer afternoons, in the hutch corner during winter nights. The wall stands where it has always stood.

Different bodies. Different responses. The same walls closing around both.

The tall-bodies' scent shifts over accumulating seasons. The smaller one carries new notes now, something sharper beneath the sweet. The voices change too, higher sounds becoming lower, breaking in ways that vibrate strangely through air.

Both tall-bodies grow. Longer strides, different rhythms. Hands larger, fingers longer, pressure different when they touch fur.

The seasons cycle. The tall-bodies continue changing. The bodies in the yard change only as seasons demand: fur thickening, fur thinning, appetite rising and falling with temperature.

Winters gather over summers. The paths deepen with each circuit the body makes. The hollow beneath the hawthorn fits more closely around each back pressed into it. The body carries the seasons as it carries everything: in fur that thickens and thins, in joints that move differently in warmth and cold, in muscles shaped by what they do over and over.

Sister's nesting happens each spring. Hay carried, fur pulled, hollow prepared for what never arrives. The nesting ends the same way: waiting, then not-waiting, then the hollow left behind as summer takes hold.

The gate still sounds. The food still comes. The hands still reach through, keeping the rhythm going.

Another winter passes.

The cold comes with the same weight, but the body moves slower through it. Joints ache in ways that take longer to ease. The stiffness stays into the day, beyond the first movement of morning. The burst of speed that once carried the body across the yard in two bounds now takes three, then four. Hind legs weaker, covering less ground.

Both bodies press closer in the hutch corner, sharing more warmth to make up what each provides less of. Sister's fur mingled with this body's own, warmth gathered in the pocket between.

Spring arrives anyway. The earth softens. The hawthorn flowers, scattering white petals over the hollow where sister has already begun carrying hay.

The cycle continues.

The bodies continue, growing slower, growing smaller somehow even as the seasons pile on top of each other. The pattern holds. The gate sounds. The food arrives.

The earth waits beneath, patient, receiving what falls.

Chapter 5: Nesting

Spring presses from below.

The earth softens after weeks of rain. Hawthorn buds swell, then open into pale flowers that release a heavy sweetness. The scent hangs thick in the air. The hollow beneath the roots holds the season's damp, dark earth under old stems. Moisture rises from the ground, cool against the nostrils.

Sister does not stay beside the body.

Warmth breaks away from the flank. Her paws scrape through the hollow, nose pressed to earth, lifted toward the flowers. One circle, then another. The body reaches its nose toward her, meets fur already moving past.

Grains of earth fall against the forepaws. Sister is moving toward the hutch.

The rack in the hutch holds dried grass, golden and sweet-scented. Sister's teeth close around a mouthful, pull stems free. Then another. Then a third, until hay sticks out on both sides of her nose. Jaws held open around the load.

She carries it over the threshold, out through the open door, across packed earth to the hollow beneath the hawthorn. Drops it, presses with her nose, pushes the stems close against the roots. The scent of sun-warmed hay mingles with hawthorn blossom.

Back to the hutch. More hay. More carrying. Her paws tread the same clods again and again. The body stands beside the path; dry stems brush its cheek as sister passes.

The hollow fills slowly. Hay upon hay, the edges rising around the center. Sister circles, presses with nose and forepaws, turns back toward the hutch. A stem falls at the body's feet. Teeth close around it, grind until only the dry taste remains.

The body rests near the wire.

Before the nose, sister's tracks run through the earth, back and forth between hutch and hawthorn. Her fur shines in the sunlight. Hay rustles past, the same rustling as when the hawthorn flowers fell before.

The body lowers its head to its forepaws. Lifts it again. Sister comes with more.

The hay rises until it spills beyond the hollow's edges. She steps down into the center, sinks low behind the stems. Her back still a moment, then up again. Paws on the path. The rustle of hay.

Sister curls over her belly. Neck bent, teeth buried in the soft underfur. The skin stretches, then a pale tuft between her teeth.

She lays the fur in the nest.

More pulling. Her side jerks, stems and fur catch around her mouth. Pink skin shows where fur lay thick. The tufts gather in the center, pale against the hay.

The body approaches. Warm sister-scent rises from the lining. Nose pressed to a loose tuft at the edge, softness yielding without skin beneath, without her weight. Sister bends again. A paw knocks against the hay, draws it closer.

The body stays at the edge until sister steps down. The stems bend outward beneath her, close around her sides.

The nest complete.

Sister settles in the hollow, belly pressed to the soft lining. Hawthorn branches shade her back, roots break the wind close to the ground. A branch sways above her; light moves through the flowers and over her fur.

She stays.

The body lies beside the nest's edge. Warmth through hay, fainter than fur against fur. The nose finds the lining again, sister-scent thick in it. Only her breathing moves the stems.

Light shifts across the yard, shadows lengthen over the ground. Sister rises, circles on the lining, lowers her belly again. The body presses its side closer. A sharp stem against the skin.

Nothing comes.

Sister returns to the nest each afternoon, circles, settles. The body follows her scent to the hawthorn. The fur at the nest's center has lost its fresh scent, flattened by pressure, grayed with dust. Rain drips through the branches. The hay smells of damp and earth now.

What was soft has become dense, pressed flat. The nest's shape remains. The edge sinks, loose stems slip out across the earth.

Nose down to the edge. Sister lifts her head, her breath warm against the whiskers. The body does not enter. Lies beside her, where her warmth reaches through the hay.

She stays until shadow covers both. When she rises, the lining lies still, pressed to the shape of her belly. No movement beneath the fur she has left there.

Fewer footsteps on the path.

Sister still visits the nest, still settles in the hollow, but stays for shorter stretches. She sprawls in the grass beside it. The body closes against her side and warmth passes through fur without hay between.

Belly fur grows back slowly. The body grooms her belly, tongue meeting short soft hairs where skin lay bare. The nest remains, fur and hay pressed into a mat. Sister passes it on her way to the bowl, back to the grass.

Nothing came.

The hawthorn sheds its flowers. Petals drift onto the nest, onto bare earth, onto the path between hutch and roots. They brown against the ground. The air warms, the days lengthen. Sister's breaths deepen against the body's side.

Earth hardening, then softening again. Hawthorn flowers above the roots. Warmth breaks away from the flank. Sister's paws on the path. Hay rustling past the nose.

She carries. She pulls fur. The lining fills with sister-scent, is pressed down beneath her belly. The body lies at the edge. The same warmth through hay, the same breathing that moves the stems.

Then hay growing cold. Petals over the lining.

Sister rests in the hawthorn's shade, near the nest. The body at the wire, nose to mesh, scents from beyond passing through. Sunlight dapples the ground between shadows.

Two bodies in the yard. The nest holds nothing. Summer unfolds over both.

Chapter 6: Middle Years

Routine deepens into the body.

The gate sounds each morning, each evening. Hands reach through with food and water. The yard holds its boundaries, the boundaries hold the body that has traced them countless times.

The wire holds, reinforced many seasons ago. The body circles the perimeter each morning, nose seeking weakness that does not come. Sister nests when spring arrives. The patterns repeat without variation, seasons circle, years gather in worn paths and bodies growing heavier, slower, grayer around the nose.

The tall-bodies have changed too. Their voices have settled lower, the breaking sounds giving way to steadier tones. They visit less often now, their attention briefer.

The bodies in the yard adjust. Food comes when food comes. Between visits, rest.

A new scent comes with autumn.

Musty and sharp, carrying traces of ammonia. Something that hunts. The body freezes, heart quickening. Predator.

The source appears above the fence. Small, fur patched orange and white. Young. It drops into the yard, lands clumsily.

The body flattens in the hollow. Sister does the same, breath quick beside.

The small predator moves forward, testing the ground. Ears high. Tail up.

The body moves forward, toward it. Heart racing. Muscles tight. But something drives the body forward instead of away. This is the body that ate first, that led, that gnawed through wire.

Sister stays in the hollow. The body rises on its hind legs. Thumps.

The sound cracks through the air. The small predator startles, scrambles backward. Another thump. The body lunges forward.

The predator leaps upward, catches the fence edge, pulls itself over. Gone.

The predator returns. Seasons pass and it grows. Each time it drops into the yard, each time the body rises, each time the thumping comes, each time it flees.

The pattern holds.

Full-grown now. Thick fur, eyes fixed on the hollow. But it does not enter. It lies on the far side of the fence, tail tip twitching. Watching.

From the hollow: the heart quickens, but the body does not rise. The predator stays on the other side of the wire.

The joints ache more in damp weather now. The hops come slower. The urgency that once drove the body toward the beyond has settled into something quieter.

Sister stays closer, rests longer. The grooming continues between them, tongue working through fur that has grown coarser.

Two bodies in the hollow as evening comes. Predator-scent at the edges, ears turned toward the wire.

The hawthorn has grown. Its branches spread wider, the trunk thicker. The hollow beneath has widened too, shaped by years of pressing bodies, worn smooth by fur and use.

Both bodies fit more easily now. Worn together. Shaped together. The hollow is theirs in a way that cannot be dug away.

The tree carries seasons the body does not count. The tree continues while the bodies slow beneath it.

The tall-bodies' visits grow shorter. Sometimes only hands, placing bowls, withdrawing. Footsteps continue beyond the wire, voices fade.

The bodies adjust. They eat what is given when it is given. The hollow, the warmth, sister pressed close.

With spring, sister carries hay again. She pulls fur from her belly, but less fur gathers in the hollow than before. Longer between trips with hay, longer before the nest covers the earth. She lies there and waits. Soon it lies empty again.

The cycle weakens even as it continues.

The hops that once carried the body across the yard now come with pauses between. The landing after each hop takes longer to settle.

The body approaches the wire sometimes, nose pressed to mesh. Scents from beyond still drift through: forest, earth, the territories of others. The body breathes them in, and that is enough.

Returns to the hollow instead. The familiar curve receives, sister's familiar warmth pressed close.

Not youth anymore. Not age yet, though age presses at the edges, makes itself felt in aching joints and slower movements.

The middle is now, and the middle holds everything: hawthorn spreading above, the hollow worn smooth below, sister whose scent has become one with the hollow, with the hawthorn, with every place the body rests.

The seasons keep turning. The pattern holds until something turns it toward an end.

For now: the middle. The continuation. Two bodies in the hollow as the light thins, warmth shared, breathing in rhythm.

This is what the years have made.



Figure 2: Middle Years

Chapter 7: Change

The scent changes first.

Something beneath the familiar smell of fur and warmth, something metallic and sharp, faint at first, then stronger with each day. Sister carries it in the mornings, rising from the hollow with the new scent clinging to her hind legs.

Iron. Sweetness beneath.

The body registers it. The heart keeps its usual rhythm. Sister moves more slowly, but she has moved slowly before. She eats less, but she has eaten less before.

Sister's belly grows heavy, rounder than before. Not the swelling of nesting season. This is different. The belly hangs lower, presses against the ground when she rests.

The iron scent strengthens.

Sister rests more, breathes more slowly. The food dish draws her less often. When she eats, only mouthfuls before returning to rest.

The body eats first. When the teeth fall quiet, sister is still lying in the hollow. Her nose lifts toward the dish, sinks again.

The tall-bodies' scent grows sharper. They reach through the gate more often, hands touching sister's sides, pressing gently against the swollen belly.

Sister stiffens beneath the hands. A brief twitch through her flank, then stillness again. Her breaths come closer together until the pressure eases.

The tall-bodies make more sounds. Low voices, short words with pauses between.

The bodies alone again, the larger one resting in the hollow, the smaller one circling along the fence.

A new enclosed space inside the gate. Straw within, cold metal at the opening. The carrier.

The tall-bodies lift sister gently, hands cradling the heavy belly, and lower her into the carrier's darkness. Sister's scent fades as the carrier moves away, beyond the wire around the yard.

The body is alone.

The yard holds no warmth now.

The hollow holds only sister's lingering scent, fading with each hour. The body circles, nose to ground, reading what remains.

The gate sounds. One tall-body appears. Hands reach through with food.

The body eats alone for the first time since the first darkness. Silence around the eating, no other body waiting, no warmth to return to.

The hollow is cold when the body settles. The curve holds the shape of two bodies, but only one body fills the space.

The body wakes at intervals, nose testing the air for scent that should be there. Each time: nothing.

Night sounds fill the silence where breathing should be. And something else: the predator's scent, fainter than before but present at the fence.

The hind legs tense. The body rises a little, sinks back. No fur against its side. The earth beneath the paws stays silent.

Dawn brightens along the wire. The nose searches the ground where the carrier stood.

The tall-bodies carry it back to the yard, place it inside the gate. Their scent has changed again, salt and damp, the particular smell of water on faces. Their voices break when they speak, words catching in throats, sounds interrupted by other sounds.

The carrier door opens.

The scent that comes is wrong.

Iron, overwhelming. Sweetness rotting beneath it. And something else, something that was warmth, now cold. Something that was movement, now still. Sister lies in the carrier, partly wrapped in cloth, eyes closed, chest not rising.

The body approaches, nose forward. Presses against the familiar fur. Cold. No response. No heartbeat vibrating through the touch. No breath warming the fur where breath should be.

Pressing harder. Nose beneath sister's chin, side against hers. Fur cold along the whole flank. No pressure in return.

Nothing.

Sounds above.

Salt-water scent rises from the tall-bodies, streams running down their faces. They crouch near the carrier, near the body still pressing against the cold fur. Shoulders jerk. Breaths catch, break into sounds that do not become words.

Hands reach into the carrier, lift the wrapped stillness. Sister is carried away, out of the yard, beyond the wire, to a place the body cannot follow.

The iron scent lingers in the air where the carrier stood, then scatters with the wind. Beneath the hawthorn the older scent remains, faint in the earth, in the fur caught between the roots.

The hollow holds only the body now.

The body circles it, presses into its curve, rises, circles again. The shape is wrong, too wide for one body, too cold without the warmth that filled the other half. The curve remembers. The earth holds the impression of two bodies, the place where sister lay, where her head rested.

The gate sounds. Food arrives. The body does not approach.

Night comes again, and the hollow holds only one heartbeat, one breath, one body that fits poorly into the space made for two.

The scent fades further with each passing hour.

Soon, only earth will remain.

Chapter 8: Absence

The hollow holds the shape of loss.

The curve remembers two bodies, but only one settles there now. The depression where sister rested holds only air, only the last traces of scent fading into earth.

The body circles the empty space. Nose to ground, reading what remains. Each circuit finds less. Each circuit erases something: the scent of now, the warmth of the living body moving through a space where movement changes nothing.

Everything fades. Returns to earth and hay and the single body that remains.

The food dish stands untouched.

The gate sounds, hands reach through, pellets pile up. The body approaches, circles the dish, turns away. The belly pulls toward emptiness.

The tall-bodies reach through the wire, hands pressing gently, sounds softer now. Their scent still carries traces of salt water.

Warmth from palms through fur. When the hands withdraw, the wind reaches the skin again. The body presses against the empty side of the hollow.

Wind moves through the hawthorn.

It carries sounds the body has heard before, the whisper of branches, the rustling of leaves still clinging despite autumn's pull. The sound fills the yard, fills the space beneath bare branches, fills the space where breathing used to be. Branches rub together, the dry sound of wood on wood. Leaves whirl in sudden gusts, scrape along the ground, rustle against the wire.

The ears turn toward it, taut. The sound could be movement. Could be the shift of a body settling into straw. Could be breath rising and falling, the rhythm that fell into step without effort through all those seasons.

The body rises from the pressed earth, turns toward the sound. Nothing there but wind and wood and the space where something was and is not.

The ears lower. The body returns to the pressed earth, to the curve that holds its shape. The wind continues, carrying nothing but wind.

The nose searches. Every corner of the yard. Every place where scent once gathered. Every path worn by years of crossing together.

The body presses its nose against the wire. Beyond carries its scents: other fences, others' ground. But beneath these layers, nothing. Not the scent that would place her there.

The wire holds firm. Beyond has nothing left to draw the body through.

Days pass. The food stays untouched. The tall-bodies come more often.

Another hand arrives. A different scent: cold metal, sharp alcohol. The body stiffens, heart racing. But no carrier. Only examination here, hands pressing along the body's sides.

The hands release. Low voices above, the alcohol scent still in the fur. The body returns to the space beneath the hawthorn.

The hollow still holds scent.

Fainter each day, but still there. The nose presses into the earth where sister lay, where warmth gathered through the seasons, where fur fell and was pressed into the soil. The scent rises, less than before, a shadow of what was.

Breathing it in. Holding it. Breathing again.

This is what remains: not the body, not the warmth, not the heartbeat that answered the other heartbeat. Only the scent, fading. Only the shape pressed into earth. Only the hollow made for two that holds one. The earth yields beneath the nose, damp and cold, and beneath the damp, beneath the cold, sister's scent lingers a little longer.

The nose presses deeper, presses after what pressure cannot reach. The scent draws farther into the earth, mingles with earth, becomes earth.

Soon it will be gone entirely. The nose stays there, breathing what remains. Simply holding: what is, what was, what the nose can still find when it searches.

One morning the body approaches the food dish. The belly has hollowed. Teeth close around the pellets. The grinding begins.

The body eats, and the belly fills, and the emptiness becomes another kind of emptiness. Full of food, still empty of what food cannot replace.

The tall-bodies reach through with fresh water, extra hay. Voices rise, hands resting against the fur.

The body allows the touch. The hands carry warmth the body cannot make alone.

The body approaches the wire sometimes, nose pressed to mesh. The urgency that once drove the body to escape has grown quieter.

Sister never went through the opening. Sister stayed, waited, met the return with grooming and warmth. Now there is no one to return to.

The predator appears more often now. Its scent lingers at the fence, stronger each time. It watches from beyond the wire, eyes fixed. The body stays in the hollow, hind legs folded beneath the belly.

The same legs that struck the earth, thump after thump, while sister lay behind. Now only a faint trembling.

The wire holds firm. The boundary is complete. The curved earth holds what remains of scent, and the body stays close to what is fading.

The hawthorn prepares for winter.

Leaves yellow, curl, release. They drift onto the depression worn smooth, onto the pressed earth where two bodies used to rest.

The cold comes earlier this year, or the body notices it more. The curved space offers less warmth with only one body to warm it. The straw in the hutch draws the body to longer rests.

Frost stays longer in the shade. The body pulls straw closer around the belly. No nest. The body has never built nests, only watched while sister carried hay and pulled fur for what never came.

What never came. What will never come now.

The hollow holds its shape. The body holds what the hollow holds. Wind moves through bare branches, carrying nothing but cold.

Chapter 9: One Body

The hollow belongs to one body now.

Where two depressions once curved side by side, a single depression holds the nights. The other curve has filled with fallen leaves, with the slow erasure of what was.

The body circles before settling. The hollow receives only one body.

Straw from the hutch has been carried here, piece by piece. Not the nest sister used to make. Only a thin layer between belly and ground.

The hollow holds one body, one breath, one heartbeat.

Winter settles. Days shrink. The ground hardens. The hawthorn stands bare above.

The body retreats to the hutch more often, but the hollow calls. Even in the deepest cold it returns to press into the curved earth, to breathe the air that still carries, perhaps carries, the faintest trace of what was. Each visit finds less.

Cold bites more sharply when the body lies alone. The warmth that filled the hollow when two bodies pressed together is no longer there. Night presses frost deeper through the fur, reaches the skin, works toward the bones. The body curls tighter, holding in what warmth it gives.

Wind carries sounds.

Sometimes a rhythm the ears reach toward, a pattern that could be breathing.

Never is.

The listening continues, alert to sounds it may never hear again. The sound of another heart.

All sounds now point toward a single body.

The body shrinks. Bones show more beneath the fur. The body eats, but does not hold what it takes in.

The tall-bodies' hands stay longer against the body. Fingers follow the back, pause at bones that once lay deeper beneath the fur.

The hands release. Ribs rise and fall beneath the thin skin.

The predator returns.

Its scent comes first, musty and sharp. The body stiffens at the trace of it, muscles taut.

The predator appears at the fence. The same thick fur. The same slow steps. The old movement begins in the hind legs, weight shifting back, front paws lifting from the earth.

Then down again.

Muscles tremble. The ground receives the paws without a thump. Behind the body, sister's place lies empty. No quick breaths there, no fur moving as the body rises.

The heart races anyway.

The body retreats to the hutch, into wooden walls, into straw and darkness. The space where two bodies once pressed close through winter nights.

Now there is no one behind.

The predator comes closer.

It moves along the fence, stops at a post. Tail tip twitching. One paw against the wire.

The wire rattles. The predator pulls itself over the edge and lands on the earth of the yard. No thumping answers.

The hutch door is still open after feeding.

The predator approaches. Pauses at the threshold. Enters.

Inside the wooden walls. Inside the straw and darkness. Inside the space the body defended through the seasons.

The body flattens against the back wall. Nowhere to run. Only the body and the approaching predator.

The predator moves without hurry. Eyes fixed. The hind legs draw tighter beneath the belly. Front paws press against the straw, but the body cannot rise. The wooden wall hard against the back.

The predator's breath reaches the fur now, warm and damp. Its scent fills the hutch, pushing everything else aside. Paws tread softly on straw, each step bringing it closer. The body's muscles tighten further, pressing the back against wood that does not give.

Sound from beyond the hutch.

Voices carrying alarm. Footsteps, quick, urgent.

The predator turns. Moves toward the hutch door, slips through, disappears as the tall-bodies arrive. Hands reach into the hutch, checking. The door closes. Latched now.

Voices above, sounds that could be soothing. Hands touch the fur, stroke once, twice, then withdraw.

The body does not unfold from its frozen crouch for a long time.

The light shifts. The predator's scent fades. The heart slows by degrees.

The nose turns toward the corner where sister used to lie. The straw gives beneath the pressure, gives no warmth in return. The body draws its legs closer.

The door holds. Latched now. The tall-bodies return.

The body approaches the wire sometimes, nose pressed to mesh. The predator still moves somewhere beyond. The wire holds firm between.

Beyond once held escape and return to a body that waited. Now there is no one waiting.

The ground softens. The hawthorn flowers again. Hay hangs in the rack, no strands carried to the hollow. Leaves spread their shade over the empty place among the roots.

Another winter approaches.

The cold comes sharper, or the body feels it deeper. The days shrink, and the body shrinks with them.

The hollow holds what remains. The curve of earth worn smooth. Scent of damp and roots. The body presses sideways, toward the old place, and meets only earth.

The body settles into the hollow as night comes. The heartbeat slows. The breathing slows. Cold presses in, and the warmth the body makes presses back, and the balance holds.

Another night. Another morning. Another season turning toward its end.

The hollow waits. The body waits. The earth waits beneath, patient, receiving what falls.

Chapter 10: Return

Winter light lies thin across the ground.

The hawthorn stands bare above the hollow, branches reaching toward gray sky.

The body moves less now. Steps come slowly, each asking more than the one before. The warmth that once ran through everything has begun to thin, withdraw toward the center.

The hollow still holds the shape. The curve of earth worn smooth by two bodies through all the seasons. The nose follows it, finds hawthorn and soil. One body now. The emptiness counts itself.

Frost comes in the mornings. The body waits for the warmth that used to press against it, the warmth that never comes now. Each morning the waiting is shorter.

The gate still sounds. Food and water, low voices. Visits grow shorter. Hands reach down sometimes, touch the fur, withdraw. They carry more warmth than they used to, or the body carries less.

The body eats less. Returns to the hollow, sinks into the worn curve.

Scent of earth and hawthorn.

The nose searches among the roots, presses deeper into the soil. The body settles with space left at its side. Sister's flank used to lie warm against its own there. Now wind strokes through the fur.

Wind moves through the bare branches above. It carries sounds that could be breathing.

The ears turn toward it. The body rises, only a little, listening for the rhythm that used to match its own. Heartbeat answering heartbeat.

No. Only wind. Wind moving through hawthorn, through the hollow, through the emptiness where sister pressed close.

Snow falls one night.

The body wakes. White covers everything. The air hangs still and cold. The body's breath rises visibly, small clouds that disappear.

The hollow lies clear beneath the branches. Old habit carries the body toward it. Legs stiff. Joints aching. Each hop slower.

The hollow receives the body as it always has. The curved earth walls press inward. The body settles, breathing slowing, the heart beating its quiet rhythm.

This is the place. This has always been the place.

Days pass. Or perhaps they pass. Light comes and goes, though the body does not always rise to meet it. The gate sounds somewhere far away. Footsteps sometimes, a dish against the ground. Hands touch the fur, gentle pressure, warmth through fur.

The body stays in the hollow.

The hands release. The gate closes and the footsteps fade beyond the wire. Only wind through branches now, one breath close to the ground.

The pull that has lived in it since the first darkness, the pull toward earth, toward enclosed space, toward the safety of down and deep. That pull has found its answer here. Not the tunnel the body tried to dig in packed earth. Not the darkness beneath the wooden floor. But this: the hollow beneath the hawthorn, shaped by years of pressing, by seasons of resting, by two bodies and then one.

Earth beneath. At last, truly: earth beneath.

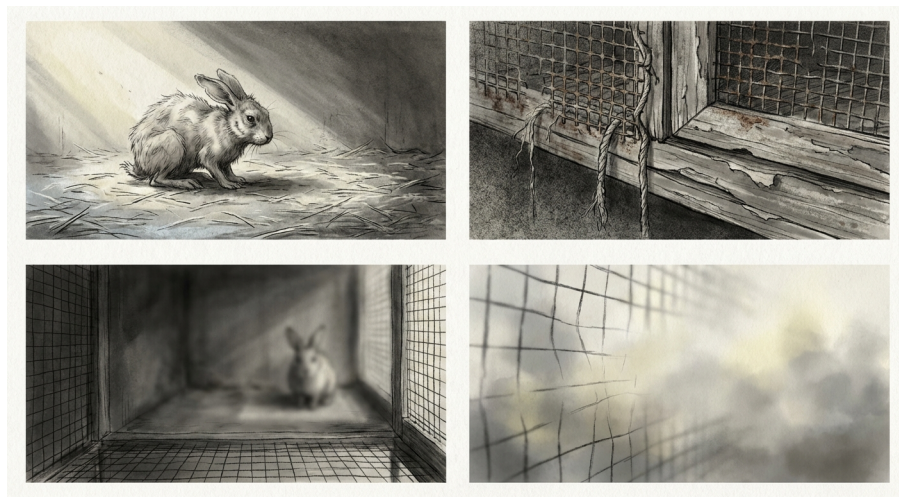


Figure 3: Return

The heart slows.

The body registers it. No twitch of muscle, no quickening. Each beat comes after a longer pause now. The breathing follows the slowing. Shallow. Slow. Cold seeps deeper, or warmth draws farther away. The difference does not count.

The nose still catches traces. Hawthorn bark. Frozen earth. The body sinks into the worn curve, flank turned toward the place where sister lay. Muscles loosen, the same movement as through all those nights when fur pressed against fur.

The warmth at its side is gone. The breathing gone. The body still holds the shape: fur pressed against fur, another heartbeat close.

The light wanes.

Evening or eyes closing. No difference. The hollow holds the body. Earth presses up from beneath, no longer cold, no longer anything but receiving. The pull that has always been there, since the first darkness and the first warmth, the pull downward.

The pull ends here. The earth that was never reached, through all the scratching and digging and pressing against the wooden floor. That earth opens now. Receives now. The layer between body and ground thins to nothing.

Wind moves through the hawthorn.

It carries the sound of breathing. Or carries nothing. The ears no longer turn to follow it. The body rests in the hollow, pressed against earth, sinking into the shape it has worn.

Cold comes. All the warmth there was gathers at the center, shrinks, dims. The heart beats. Beats again. The pause between stretches long.

Scent of earth. Scent of hawthorn. Scent of.

Something releases.

The body stills into its final shape. The hollow holds what it was always meant to hold. Earth receives what was always its own.

Light is. Sound is. Scent is. Earth is.

Then not separate. Then not body, not hollow, not hawthorn. Wind moves through branches and fur and the space where separation used to be.

All wind. All earth. All scent.

Fur in wind, wind in fur. No boundary between. Earth beneath body, body in earth. No boundary between. Scent, light, sound: no longer separate.

The hollow remains beneath the hawthorn, holding its shape. Spring comes again. Grass pushes through the thawing earth. New scents rise.

The gate sounds. Footsteps approach.

But the warmth that pressed here, that breathed here, that pulled toward earth through all those seasons.

That warmth is earth now. Is everything now. Is.
